

Ἀντιφάνης ὁ κωμικός

Antiphanes the Comic Poet on Food, Folly, and Feasting

eul_aid: fgy

Period: *Κλασική* Classical
Dialect: *Ἀττική* Attic (com, frg)
Domain: *Κωμωδία* Comedy
Format: *Ἑμμετρος* Verse

Antiphanes was a comic playwright of the 4th century BCE, active during the period known as Middle Comedy. Although his birthplace is uncertain—ancient sources suggest Larissa, Rhodes, or Smyrna—he worked primarily in Athens. According to later records, he lived to about 74 years old, placing his career from the late 380s BCE to around 300 BCE. He was reportedly the teacher of another comic poet, Alexis.

He was an extraordinarily prolific writer. Ancient sources credit him with between 260 and 365 plays, though the exact number is debated. Only fragments of his work survive, quoted by later authors, but titles are known for over 130 of his comedies. These include plays like *The Poet*, *The Farmer*, and *The Parasite*.

Antiphanes is a central figure for understanding the evolution of Greek comedy. His long career bridges the gap between the politically focused Old Comedy and the newer style of Middle Comedy. According to modern scholars, his fragments show a shift toward generalized social satire, domestic plots, romantic situations, and parody of mythology, moving away from direct personal and political attack. The surviving pieces provide valuable insights into 4th-century Athenian social life, food, and music. A famous fragment from his play *The Poet*, which compares the challenges faced by tragic and comic writers, is often cited in discussions of ancient theatrical practice.

Works (2)

- Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Σίτων καὶ Μωρίας · [Comic Fragments on Food and Folly](#) · 979 passages
- Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Ἔρωτος καὶ Συμποσίου · [Comic Fragments on Love and Feasting](#) · 1056 passages